

What is EMDR and How It Works

WHAT EMDR IS • HOW IT WORKS • RESOURCING • PHASES 1–8

What EMDR Is

EMDR helps the brain process distressing experiences that still feel present.

When an experience overwhelms our ability to cope, the memory can remain linked to the emotions, beliefs, body sensations, and survival responses that occurred at the time. Later, a reminder may activate that old alarm even when we know we are safe now.

During EMDR, you briefly notice a target memory while using bilateral stimulation—such as guided eye movements, alternating taps, or tones. You remain awake, aware, and in control.



Trauma is not literally stored in a muscle or body part. Body sensations can be part of how an insufficiently processed memory is experienced and activated.

Adaptive Information Processing (AIP)

Our brain has a natural capacity to heal. Through Adaptive Information Processing, experiences are understood and stored in a balanced way.

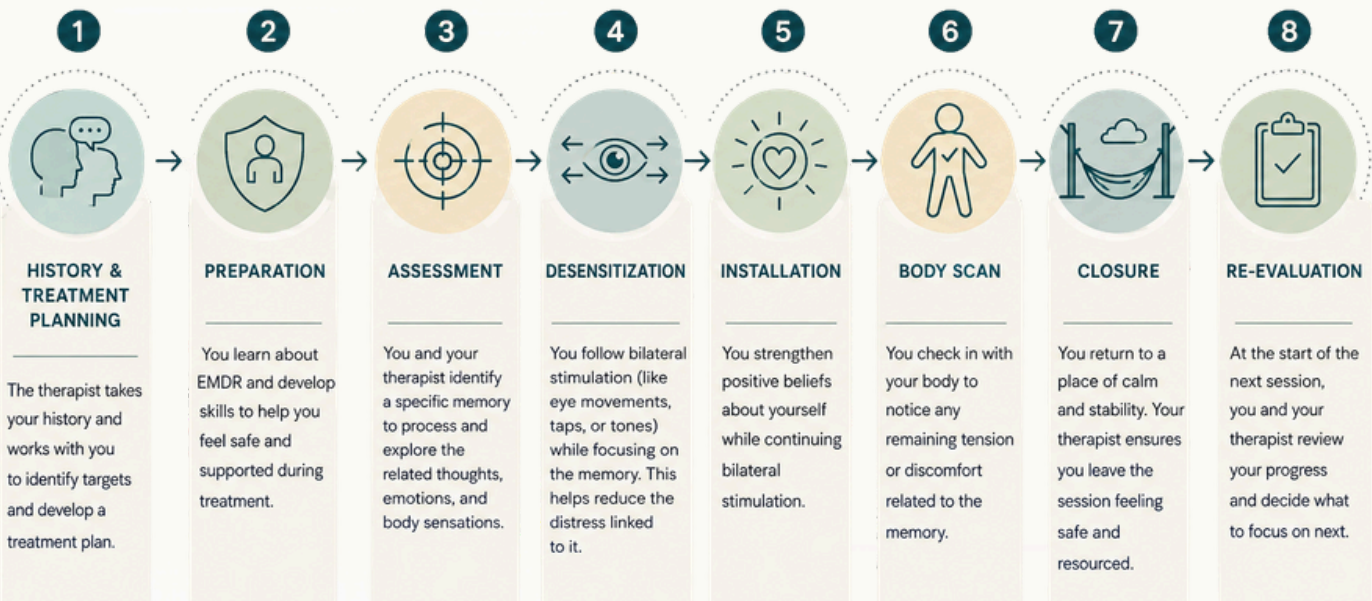
When processing is incomplete due to overwhelm, the memory can get “stuck” with the original emotions, beliefs, and survival responses.

EMDR is a form of therapy that reprocesses these memories so they no longer carry the same level of distress.

The goal is not to erase the memory, but to help the brain store it in a way that feels like something that happened in the past rather than something happening now.

The 8 Phases of EMDR

EMDR therapy is a structured, 8-phase approach that helps the brain heal from distressing memories and supports adaptive information processing.



Present Triggers and Activation

Current reminders—sights, sounds, thoughts, smells, places, or situations—can activate the unprocessed memory network.

The body and brain respond as if the original event is happening now, bringing old emotions, physical sensations, and survival responses into the present.

This is not a choice or weakness—it is how the brain is trying to protect you.

Parts-Work Note

Protective responses, such as avoidance, shutdown, control, anger, people-pleasing, perfectionism, and hypervigilance, serve as parts that help us cope. EMDR encourages curiosity and gentle exploration rather than force, fostering safety and integration.

Resourcing and Readiness

Before deeper processing, therapy builds present-day stability through grounding, breathing, safe or calm imagery, sensory anchors, supportive figures, mastery memories, and containment.

Key Resourcing Tools

- Grounding (breath, body, environment)
- Calm imagery (safe place)
- Containment (container, boundaries)
- Supportive figures
- Sensory anchors (sights, sounds, textures, scents, tastes)
- Mastery memories (successes, strengths, coping wins)

